



TELLING AND SHOWING

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What is telling?

- Telling is simply the mention of statements plainly, without proof or actions to back them up.
- For example, the simple mention that somebody is cold or kind or scared is telling.
- Telling is a broad, direct and simplified way of summarizing information briefly.

Is Telling Wrong?

- Good writing is always a blend of showing plus telling.
- Telling is crucial when depicting passage of time and conveying important facts to a reader.

- For writings that aim to stand out, telling's broad, direct and simple nature can inherently work against standing out.
- With telling too, comes the mode of dictation where a writer points out the emotions, scenes and actions to the reader. However, good story-telling doesn't point out the facts to the reader. They invite the reader to fill in the gaps for themselves.

EXAMPLES OF TELLING

1. I was a shy student in class. I never socialized with my classmates.
2. I am fascinated by electric devices. I fix our home appliances when they falter.
3. Taiyo had a crush on Parmuat.
4. He is cold.

What is Showing?

- Showing is the use of actions and scenes to depict emotions and experiences, fully immersing the reader into a process of discovery and empathy of the characters in the text.
- For example, in telling the reader, a writer will say somebody is cold but in showing the reader, the writer would visualize a character shivering.

- In telling, a writer will state a character is kind. In showing, the writer will give us his actions of helping others and volunteering for good causes.
- In telling, a writer will state a character was scared. In showing, a writer can say ‘his sweaty palms trembled irresistibly’

Is Showing Always Good?

- Good writing is always a blend of showing plus telling.
- If all writers aimed at was showing, books would be awfully long and crucial facts would end up being blubbered.

- It is showing's ability to immerse the reader in the text and make him/her work for the facts in the writing that makes showing a crucial tool in writing.
- For you writers that aim to be outstanding, a combination of showing plus telling will help you out.

EXAMPLES OF SHOWING

- Instead of saying ‘**I was shy**’, once could show by saying ‘I rarely talked in class. Each year, I would resolve to ask and answer three questions every lesson. Sadly, I failed to uphold this resolution. Anytime I wanted to speak in public, a breeze rushed over me. One stammer, two stammers, and, by the time the third stammer was coming out, the confidence to speak had fizzled like a Dothraki cavalry charge. Disappointed, I would affirm within me that speaking wasn't my mojo unless it was talking to myself.’

- Instead of saying ‘I am fascinated by electric devices’, a writer can show through ‘The click of the switch and the flicker of the bulb to shine bright yellow amazed me. I simply thought it was magic then. School would later deconstruct it not as magic but as a movement of electrons. From there, I began to understand electricity. In my spare time at home, I continuously tinkered with electronic gadgets, in spite of the knowledge that my father would chasten me for toying with his devices. I hung out with *jua kali*(shade-tree) mechanics and learnt about powering farm machinery. On one occasion, a neighbour's mill power unit had the unit's fuse blown up. I removed the blown fuse and using a thin copper wire, helped jerry-rig the power unit. After turning on the power unit, the pounding of the posho mill stamped in my ambition to become an electrical engineer.’

GUIDING PRINCIPLES OF SHOWING

1. USING EVIDENCE TO SUPPORT YOUR CLAIMS

If you experienced financial turmoil at home, use evidences such as wearing torn clothes and shoes, having one meal a day, using a kerosene lamp to foster these claims.

If your passionate about mechanical engineering, use evidences such as fixing your father's car, making vehicle toys out of wires or watching Fast and Furious to foster these claims.

TELLING: Everyone knew Mwadime was lazy.

SHOWING: *His unkempt hair was breeding ground for flies. When he shook his head, waves of dandruff dust fell off with ease. His withdrawn eyes depicted no motivation. The top of his locker had been his best friend. Between sleeping on it during classes, and the smell of pork soup from unwashed utensils within the locker, that locker top was all he knew in school, almost as if he woke up just to see it everyday.*

“Instead of characters knowing anything, you must now present the details to allow the reader to know them. Instead of a character wanting something, you must now describe the thing so that the reader wants it,”

-Charles Palahniuk

2. REPLACE THE ABSTRACT WITH THE CONCRETE

- Instead of mentioning emotions bluntly, show by giving substantial evidences to back up the feeling.

TELLING: Bul walked on home feeling happy.

SHOWING: Bul strutted away, his swaying arms in sync with his 10000-watt smile which lit up his face like the Equatorial sun. That night sleep didn't overpower him. Eight hours were wasted on left and right turning accompanied with a

3. SUBSTITUTE VAGUE DESCRIPTIONS WITH SPECIFIC SENSORY DETAILS

- As showing relies on specifics, unique sensory details makes feelings and experiences jump off the page.
- Make the scenes look three-dimensional.

TELLING: She cherished his husband more than anything.

SHOWING: As she clenched his arm around her, she gazed deep into his eyes. Her fingers rolled through his thick set of beards, lacing them with her magnolia scent, almost as if she was marking her territory.

UNIFYING THEORY OF SHOWING AND TELLING

- Superior writers like Andrew Stanton(*Toy Story*) advise the unifying theory of showing being 2+2, in the college application process you will most often show using 2+2 and tell the admissions officers that it is equal to 4.
- The key is to engage the readers of your application, make them work to discover you, make them fill in the gaps and get who you are as a picture.
- (<https://youtu.be/KxDwieKpawg>)

FOOTBALL
COMMENTARY SHOWING
AND NOT TELLING

PETER DRURY

“Now Pep Guardiola will look to the available soldiers on his bench and Gabriel Jesus has been summoned. It has been confirmed that David Silva will make way for the striker. Yes, Silva for Jesus. A substitution Judas Iscariot would have been proud of”

“Under-kooooo. Roma have risen from their ruins. Manolas! The Greek god in Rome! The unthinkable unfolds before our eyes. This was not meant to happen. This could not happen. This is happening. Barcelona extraordinarily eight minutes from elimination. And Di Francesco does not know where to go. Iniesta does not know where to look. It is a Greek from Mount Olympus who has come to the seven hills of Rome and pulled of a miracle.”

ROY HUDSON

“Ooooooh! Are you kidding me? Astonishing. This is not just a dream. It’s a wet dream of orgasmic proportions. And this one deludes everybody. It seduces everybody in Real Madrid’s flank that’s for sure. A wonder strike from Cristiano.”

MARTIN TYLER

“Welcome to the final episodes of this spellbinding saga to crown the new Premier League Kings. Jurgen Klopp will send out his red dragons to scorch the St. James’s Park turf so he can spend another long night at the Iron Throne. But loose and Liverpool’s quest for glory in the North will fizzle out like a Dothraki cavalry charge. Rafa Benitez you saw him a few moments ago. He bent the knee to the house of St. James after conquering the kingdoms of Europe when he ruled over Anfield. He’ll demand the toon army stand their ground like Brienne of Tarth and hope that Ayoze Stark can produce a dagger to shatter the hopes of his former club”